reject it entirely.[125] Pronouncements declaring the independence of Afghanistan externally as well as internally were followed with the appointment of a Commissary of Foreign Affairs, under Muhammad Tarzi.[126] As well as being Amanullah's father-in-law, Tarzi was the founder and owner of Afghanistan's only newspaper of the time, the Siraj-al-Akhbar ('Spotlight on the News'), a paper that specialised in vitriolic attacks against Britain and which had spent the entire First World War espousing the Turkish cause.[127] Such actions boded ill for the Indian government, which by April 1919 was facing its own problems with extensive internal unrest. The announcement of the Rowlatt Bill, followed by the tragedy of the Amritsar Massacre, was used by the new emir to denounce Britain's rule in India.[128] Finally, following minor skirmishes along the borders, Afghan troops violated Indian territory on 5 May 1919. Indian forces were mobilised to counter the attack, and by 11 May Amanullah had announced a jihad against Britain. The conflict was short-lived, as Afghan troops and civilians became quickly demoralised by the Indian government's campaign of aerial bombardment, and by 28 May Amanullah had despatched a request for a ceasefire.[129]

With such events in Afghanistan and India dominating his attention, it is unsurprising that Chelmsford was reluctant to become more deeply involved in Persian affairs. Signs of a link between the Bolshevik regime and the problems in Afghanistan were also highly worrying. Throughout May, Malleson had been reporting on the increase in pro-Bolshevik, pro-Islamic and anti-British propaganda being distributed in Meshed, Turkestan and Afghanistan.[130] On 30 May, Malleson had told CIGS that the Bolshevik government had officially recognised emir Amanullah and the independence of Afghanistan,[131] while, for his part, one of the first acts of the new emir was to congratulate the Soviet regime on their successes in Russia.[132] On 6 May, the Director of the Eastern Section of the People's Commissariat for Foreign Affairs in Soviet Russia had described Afghanistan in the paper Izvestiia as being 'of first class importance for the propaganda cause in Asia...Afghanistan is historically and geographically a passing stage from India to Central Asia...it exercises an enormous influence over the 70 million mussulman population of India'.[133]